

“All the News
That’s Fit to Print”

The New York Times

THE WEATHER
Today, plenty of sunshine, not as cold as recent days, high 34. **Tonight**, mostly clear, low 21. **Tomorrow**, sunny to partly cloudy, chilly, high 32. Weather map is on Page B12.

VOL. CLXXIV . . . No. 60,409 © 2025 The New York Times Company FRIDAY, JANUARY 24, 2025 Prices in Canada may be higher \$4.00



On Tuesday, Mexican National Army soldiers at the site of a tent facility for deportees that was being set up in Ciudad Juárez, Mexico. PAUL RATJE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Without Delay, Hamas Is Back In Public View

By ADAM RASGON and IYAD ABUHEWEILA
JERUSALEM — The morning the cease-fire in Gaza went into effect, masked members of Hamas’s military wing drove through the streets of Gaza in clean, white pickups, carrying Hamas flags and automatic rifles. The militants were also carrying an unambiguous message: However weakened, Hamas survived Israel’s 15-month bombing campaign in Gaza and remains the most powerful Palestinian party in the territory. Since the cease-fire started on Sunday, Hamas has been working overtime in an attempt to show it still controls Gaza, even after Israel killed thousands of its members and demolished its tunnels and weapons factories in retaliation for the Oct. 7, 2023, cross-border



ABED HAJJAR/ASSOCIATED PRESS
Hamas fighters escorted a Red Cross vehicle Sunday in Gaza City to collect Israeli hostages.

der attack that killed an estimated 1,200 people. Throughout the war, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu of Israel has vowed to eliminate Hamas, but he never offered a plan for a realistic alternative that could take control of Gaza, leaving behind a vacuum that the armed group filled. Even for many residents of Gaza, however, the swift re-emergence of the fighters, some in official uniforms, was a surprise. “They came out of hiding in a snap of a finger,” said Mohammed, 24, who requested his last name be withheld to avoid possible retribution from Hamas. “We had no idea where these people were during the war.” Later on the first day of the

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Mexico’s All-Hands Plan to Welcome Deportees

By EMILIANO RODRÍGUEZ MEGA and ANNIE CORREAL
MEXICO CITY — Mexico’s plan to receive thousands of its deported citizens from the United States is nothing short of ambitious. Plans are underway to build nine reception centers along the border — massive tents set up in parking lots, stadiums and warehouses — with mobile kitchens operated by the armed forces. Details of the initiative — called “Mexico Embraces You” — were revealed only this week, although Mexican officials said they had been devising it for the past few months, ever since Donald J. Trump pledged to conduct the largest expulsion of undocumented immigrants in U.S. history. Nearly every branch of government — 34 federal agencies and 16 state governments — is expected to participate in one way or another: busing people to their hometowns, organizing logistics, providing medical attention, enrolling the recently returned in social welfare programs like pensions and paid apprenticeships, along with handing out cash cards worth about \$100 each. Officials say they are also negotiating agreements with Mexican companies to link people to jobs. “We are ready to receive you on this side of the border,” Mexico’s interior minister, Rosa Icela Rodríguez, said at a news conference this week. “Repatriation is an opportunity to return home and be reunited with family.” President Claudia Sheinbaum of Mexico has called the expected large-scale deportations a “unilateral move” and has said she does not agree with them. But as the country with the single largest number of unauthorized citizens living in the United States — an estimated four million people as of 2022 — Mexico has found itself obligated to prepare. The government’s plan is focused on Mexicans deported from the United States, though the president has indicated the country could temporarily receive foreign deportees, too. Mexico is not alone in preparing: Guatemala, its neighbor to the south that also has a large undocumented population in the

A Showdown for Spreadsheet Glory (and a Wrestling-Style Belt)

By YAN ZHUANG
LAS VEGAS — Like soccer players taking the field in a giant stadium, the 12 finalists ran through a glowing “hype tunnel,” some wearing jerseys with sponsorship logos. As an announcer bellowed introductions and cameras captured their every move, they approached a neon-lit stage to raucous cheers. Then the men sat down at desktop computers, opened their Microsoft Excel spreadsheets and began to type. Excel, a program that does complex math on a human’s behalf, is often associated, rightly, with corporate drudgery. But last month, in a Las Vegas e-sports arena that typically hosts Fortnite and League of Legends tournaments, finance professionals fluent in spreadsheets were treated like minor celebrities as they gathered to solve devilishly complex Excel puzzles in front of an audience of about 400 people, with more watching an ESPN3 livestream. Organizers call the event the Microsoft Excel World Championship. “Yes, it is a thing,” the official website says. At stake was a \$5,000 prize, a wrestling-style championship belt and the title of world’s best spreadsheeter. But the organizer, Andrew Grigolyunovich, is dreaming bigger. He hopes to turn competitive Excel into a popular



MIKAYLA WHITMORE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
The Microsoft Excel World Championship in Las Vegas drew about 400 spectators in December.

e-sport where pros compete for million-dollar prizes and big-league glory. “Excel was always thought of as a back-office product,” said Mr. Grigolyunovich, a Sudoku champion from Latvia. But in Vegas, “these people who are working, I don’t want to say boring jobs — but, you know, regular jobs — they could become stars.” If that seems too ambitious, we’d like to introduce you to Erik Oehm, a software developer from San Francisco, who watched the action from the front row. “This is the Super Bowl for Excel nerds,” Mr. Oehm said. “If Excel is the center of your universe, this is like hanging out with LeBron James and Kobe Bryant.” The “LeBron James of Excel,” as he was introduced in Vegas, was Diarmuid Early, 39, an Irish financial consultant in New York, who entered the arena in jeans, sandals and a jersey patterned to resemble abdominal muscles. The Kobe Bryant was Andrew Ngai, 37, a soft-spoken actuary from Australia known as the Annihila-

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Pardon Is Won By Leveraging Trump’s Needs

Libertarians Help Free Online Drug Kingpin

By DAVID YAFFE-BELLANY and RYAN MAC
In December 2023, Angela McArdle, the chair of the Libertarian Party, flew to Mar-a-Lago to meet with Donald J. Trump. Mr. Trump wanted to know how to win over libertarian voters, a constituency he thought could help him reclaim the presidency, Ms. McArdle said in an interview. She had an answer: Free Ross Ulbricht, a Bitcoin pioneer who was sentenced to life in prison in 2015 for creating Silk Road, the world’s largest online drug marketplace. Mr. Ulbricht was regarded as a libertarian hero for building an illegal market outside the government’s reach. “I love freeing people,” Mr. Trump said, according to Ms. McArdle. Five months later, she hosted him at the Libertarian Party’s national convention, where he announced onstage that, if elected to the presidency, he would release Mr. Ulbricht. On Tuesday, the day after his inauguration, Mr. Trump made good on that promise. He called Mr. Ulbricht’s mother, Lyn Ulbricht, to personally tell her that he had granted a full pardon to her son, who is now 40. In a post on Truth Social, Mr. Trump said the decision was “in honor of her and the Libertarian Movement, which supported me so strongly.” Mr. Ulbricht’s pardon was not an obvious agenda item for Mr. Trump. Unlike the nearly 1,600 people who received pardons or commutations this week for their involvement in the Jan. 6 riot, Mr. Ulbricht had little direct connection to the president. But the move had long been in the works, after more than a decade of activism by Mr. Ulbricht’s supporters — including cryptocurrency investors, libertarian politicians and especially Ms. Ulbricht, a vocal proponent for her son’s release. Many of them have enjoyed an unusual level of access to Mr. Trump. As it became clear last year that Mr. Trump would be the Republican nominee, they waged

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HEGSETH NEARING SENATE APPROVAL DESPITE CONCERN

ABUSE CLAIM REBUFFED

G.O.P. Clears Way for a Final Vote on Trump’s Pick for Defense

By KAROUN DEMIRJIAN
WASHINGTON — A divided Senate on Thursday voted to move toward confirming Pete Hegseth as secretary of defense, in a strong signal that allegations about his personal conduct, including a new one from a former sister-in-law, were unlikely to derail his nomination. On a 51-to-49 vote that came down almost entirely along party lines, Republicans broke a Democratic filibuster, clearing away the final hurdle to a confirmation vote now expected on Friday evening. The action came as Democrats, who have called President Trump’s nominee to lead the Pentagon unfit, worked to persuade a handful of G.O.P. senators to join them in opposition. “We cannot risk installing a leader who may have a history that is exploitable by our adversaries,” Senator Jack Reed of Rhode Island, the top Democrat on the Armed Services Committee, said in a floor speech on Thursday. “Nor can we risk confirming a secretary of defense who has shown that he is incapable of being responsible, accountable and law abiding 24 hours a day, seven days a week, as that job requires.” In his statement, Mr. Reed referred to a sworn statement submitted to the Senate on Tuesday by a former sister-in-law of Mr. Hegseth’s who described him as frequently intoxicated and “abusive” toward his second wife. Mr. Continued on Page A17

BLOCKED A judge has temporarily halted the president’s order to end birthright citizenship. PAGE A13
BUDGET CUTS Republicans float reductions for Medicaid and many other programs. PAGE A15

The Struggle To Make Tests A.I. Can’t Ace

SAN FRANCISCO — If you’re looking for a new reason to be nervous about artificial intelligence, try this: Some of the smartest humans in the world are struggling to create tests that A.I. systems can’t pass. For years, A.I. systems were measured by giving new models a variety of standardized benchmark tests. Many of these tests consisted of challenging, SAT-caliber problems in areas like math, science and logic. Comparing the models’ scores over time served as a rough measure of A.I. progress. But A.I. systems eventually got too good at those tests, so new, harder tests were created — often with the types of questions graduate students might encounter on their exams. Those tests aren’t in good shape, either. New models from companies like OpenAI, Google and Anthropic have been getting high scores on many Ph.D.-level challenges, limiting those tests’ usefulness and leading to a chilling question: Are A.I. systems getting too smart for us to measure? Continued on Page A12



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The frequency and strength of storms in the Mediterranean have increased, and are expected to worsen. PAGE A6

Same-Sex Nuptials in Thailand
A mass wedding was held in Bangkok as the country became one of the few places in Asia to legalize the unions. PAGE A5

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Trump-Era Changes at CNN
The network announced job cuts, a wave of hiring, changes to its schedule, and a new streaming service. PAGE B1
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President Trump signals that businesses and organizations could be investigated over diversity. PAGE B1
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Elevated Vietnamese Cuisine
Charles Phan married the best local ingredients with the food he grew up on and buoyed other chefs from immigrant families. He was 62. PAGE B11



NATIONAL A10-19
Bird Flu Detected in Pet Cats
Officials have linked some of the cases to virus-laden raw milk, but other cats had consumed raw pet food. PAGE A19
Fireproof House, Singed Spirit
The Vogts built their Malibu house to withstand disasters. They weren’t ready for the mental toll of the fires. PAGE A10

WEEKEND ARTS C1-10
Wide-Open Oscar Race
In a year with no clear favorite in the best-picture category, the film “Emilia Pérez” led the way with 13 nominations, while “The Brutalist” and “Wicked” received 10 nominations apiece. PAGE C1
Where Anne Frank Hid
Covered windows, peeling wallpaper: For the first time outside of Amsterdam, an exhibition reconstructs the girl’s secret annex during the devastation of the Holocaust. PAGE C1
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Pico Iyer PAGE A20



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A Winning Combination
When Madison Keys, above, asked her husband to serve as her coach, he reluctantly agreed. Now, she’s reached the finals of the Australian Open. PAGE B8

